

The Artist OUTCAST

Losing M.F. Husain to Qatar is a shame. So is the selective fight for creative freedom.

| By S. Prasannarajan |

Maqbool Fida Husain, the famous Qatari artist of Indian origin. How does it sound? It is a name that tells the latest story of an imagination persecuted with all the routine variations of the plot: an iconic artist who believes that nothing is sacred except his brushstrokes; the aggrieved custodians of faith who rage against the profanity of the painter: his freedom curtailed and his canvases vandalised, the artist exiles himself and begins a life of homelessness, away from the state that can't protect him and people who can't appreciate him; exile, even if voluntary, is a soulless place where time stagnates, and where home is a perforated memory, so he wanders; and then, finally, freedom reaches out to him from the unlikely of places; he redeems himself from the wretchedness of his lost home and gains a new nationality; well, someone at last realises the worth of having M.F. Husain as a citizen....

Perhaps, this is too much of a straitjacket, this plot of persecution and unsolicited justice from elsewhere. The Husain saga, notwithstanding the national shame of having let him go, is too palimpsestic to fit the familiar narrative of the Artist Outcast.

Certainly, the attack on Husain's paintings by the lunatic fringe of political Hinduism cannot be condoned, and no civilised society should allow the self-styled guardians of endangered gods to become art critics. Still, Husain was not banished by the state; but the system, more specifically the legal labyrinth, was an intolerable frustration for an artist. So, instead of living with the evil, he left for more pleasant environments. His tormentors were not the official arbiters of Hinduism. They don't exist. Hinduism has no official singular point of authority, no Khomeini in saffron who can condemn the defiler to some Vedic gulag. Husain chose not to return to the hell that was home. And his new home—let us be realistic—is hardly the last hope for hounded storytellers and persecuted painters. The Emir of Qatar is the artist's

client, and the source of Husain's torment has nothing in common with those Danish cartoons. Or with the film by the publicly assassinated Theo van Gogh. Or with the writings of Ayaan Hirsi Ali. Or, let us not forget, with *The Satanic Verses* by Salman Rushdie.

This brings us straight to the selective left-liberal anguish over creative freedom. Where were they when India, succumbing to the desperate politics of Muslim ghettos, became the first country to ban *The Satanic Verses* more than two decades ago? We were, in retrospect, as enthusiastic as the Ayatollah in declaring war on the book that threat-

ened the Book. Then, those who did not stand by the writer, already on the run with a price tag on his head, did so in the name of respect-for-religious-sentiment. Ha Ha! Whatever happened to the sanctity of art? And remember, in many ways, the burning book was the precursor to the burning towers: the extra-territorial terror of religion, from fatwa to jihad. You-invited-it... you-are-paying-for-your-transgressions—the left-liberal self-righteousness was very much in the air both on that Valentine's Day 21 years ago and on that September morning nine years ago. The paranoia of Islamism would continue to

upgrade its enemy (from a blasphemous book to the entire world of the infidels) as well as its liberator (from the bearded Imam of Persia to the bearded troglodyte of Tora Bora). Afghanistan reminds us that the war for freedom is not yet over.

Freedom for Husain too is worth fighting for, and the definition of that freedom should not be set by those who continue to be selective in their struggle for creative autonomy—or in their idea of religious sentiment. The Emir of Qatar may have acquired a trophy citizen, and the new patron of art-under-attack is unlikely to extend such an invitation to other blasphemers. The emirs of secularism in India could be more generous—and honest—in their fight for freedom. Meanwhile we should get that Qatari painter back before he gets bored with his new nationality. ■

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